17TH-CENTURY EUROPEAN SOLDIERS

The 17th century was a transitional period for European armies. Infantry began the century armed with pikes and arquebuses or matchlock muskets and ended it with flintlock muskets and bayonets. The wars of the first half of the century were mostly fought by mercenary forces raised by military entrepreneurs; in later decades, standing armies predominated, although rulers continued to employ large foreign contingents in their forces. Standards of discipline gradually improved, as did the quality of army administration. Soldiers who were regularly paid and fed became less likely to mutiny or wreak havoc upon civilians. Cavalry returned to fashion after its decline in the 16th century, diversifying into heavy and light horse and dragoons.

DUTCH FOOT SOLDIERS

In the late 16th century a Dutch army, consisting of a mix of local levies and foreign volunteers or mercenaries, was fighting for independence from the rule of the Spanish Habsburgs. The Dutch had usually had the worst of any confrontation with the Spanish *tercios*, but from the 1590s onward their performance improved under the direction of Maurice of Nassau (1567–1625). The supply and payment of the army became exceptionally reliable by the standards of the time, and the infantry were drilled and disciplined in a systematic fashion.

Maurice and his advisers evolved a more flexible battlefield formation than that of the *tercios*. The Dutch infantry took the field in battalions about 500 strong, with roughly equal numbers of pikemen and "shot" – soldiers with arquebuses or muskets. The armoured pikemen deployed in a formation much broader than it was deep, usually in files of ten men from front to rear. The "shot", who flanked the pikemen, were drilled to maintain a rolling fire, each rank firing and then withdrawing to reload as the next rank fired. The pikemen held off the cavalry and provided the offensive "push of pike" to drive the enemy from the field at the decisive moment. Although the Dutch never truly got the better of the Spanish in battle, the Habsburg monarchy was eventually forced to recognize their independence formally in 1648. The Dutch system of fighting had widespread influence on European military thinking.





Dutch armour and weapons
The half armour, consisting of a breastplate, backplate, and tassets to protect the thighs, is typical of pikeman's armour in the early 17th century. So, too, is the pot helmet. The sword and decorative halberd would have belonged to an officer.

SWEDISH TROOPS

In 1620 Sweden introduced an Ordinance of Military Personnel, registering all men over 15 for military service. Some 10,000 were conscripted every year. Along with mercenaries hired from Protestant Germany, they allowed King Gustav Adolf to field a formidable army. Gustav built upon the Dutch infantry model, thinning the formation of pikemen to only six ranks and doubling the proportion of musketeers. The latter were trained to fire mass volleys in three ranks – kneeling, crouching, and standing. Gustav also made aggressive use of cavalry, charging with sabres drawn. The Swedish army intervened decisively in the Thirty Years' War, but at great cost. Of 230 conscripts recruited from one Swedish village, 215 died abroad.

FRENCH MUSKETEER

In 1622 French King Louis XIII equipped a light cavalry company of his royal household with matchlock muskets. Since this represented the latest in military technology, it helped give the musketeer company elite status. Its proximity to the king guaranteed that gentleman-soldiers would seek service in its ranks. In the 1660s two companies were created, known as the Grey Musketeers and the Black Musketeers from the colour of their sleeveless surcoats. Despite their name, these units generally preferred the sword to the musket, which, having lost its aura of novelty, was despised by the aristocracy as an arm suitable only for lowly foot soldiers. The two companies remained in existence until 1776. Their reputation for panache and flamboyance was later immortalized in the novels of Alexandre Dumas.

